



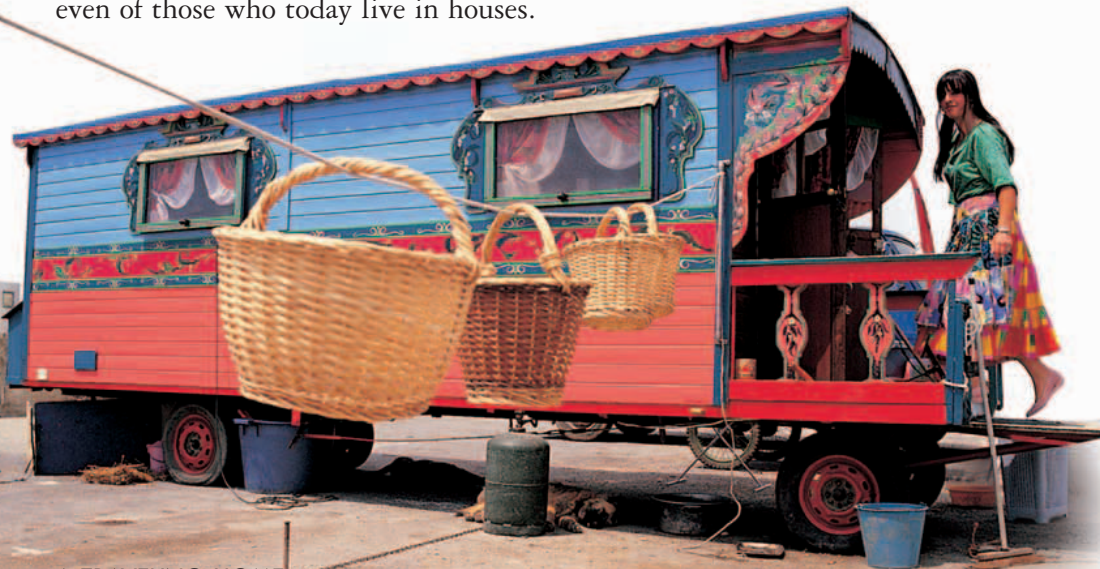
ROMA

COMMONLY CALLED GYPSIES, Roma were persecuted because their nomadic lifestyle meant they were perceived as outsiders with foreign customs and their own language. There are more than 12 million Roma

A TRADITION OF TRAVELING

Mobile home

Roma living in mobile homes value their freedom, but they also live this way because many European peoples have refused to let them set up permanent homes. Roma like to do many household activities, such as eating and cooking, out of doors. This is true even of those who today live in houses.



A TRAVELING HOME

Throughout Europe, Roma were well-known for their beautifully decorated *vardos* or caravans. This one belongs to a Roma family visiting the French village of St. Maries de la Mer. Roma gather there every May to celebrate Sarah, their patron saint. *Vardos* used to be drawn by horses, which not only provided a means of transportation, but were also at one stage a commodity that Roma bought and sold.



MARIMÉ LAWS

Roma have complex laws so they do not come into contact with anything *marimé*, or impure. Food cooked by non-Roma is *marimé*. Cooking and eating utensils must be washed in a basin used only for this purpose. It would become *marimé* if anyone were to wash their hands or launder clothes in it. Roma would prefer to eat with their hands rather than use *marimé* implements.



FUNERAL CUSTOMS

Roma funerals are big events. Dead people are buried in their best clothes and tools, food, jewelry, and money may be buried with them. After the funeral, their remaining belongings are destroyed.

